

Dietary patterns and the risk of esophageal cancer.

BACKGROUND: The role of dietary habits on esophageal cancer risk has been rarely considered in terms of dietary patterns. **PATIENTS AND METHODS:** We analyzed data from an Italian case-control study, including 304 cases with squamous cell carcinoma of the esophagus and 743 hospital controls. Dietary habits were evaluated using a food frequency questionnaire. A posteriori dietary patterns were identified through principal component factor analysis performed on 28 selected nutrients. Odds ratios (ORs) and 95% confidence intervals (CIs) were obtained from multiple logistic regression models applied on quartiles of factor scores, adjusting for potential confounding variables. **RESULTS:** We identified five major dietary patterns, named 'animal products and related components', 'vitamins and fiber', 'starch-rich', 'other polyunsaturated fatty acids and vitamin D', and 'other fats'. The 'animal products and related components' pattern was positively related to esophageal cancer (OR = 1.64, 95% CI:1.06-2.55, for the highest versus the lowest quartile of factor scores category). The 'vitamins and fiber' (OR = 0.50, 95% CI: 0.32-0.78) and the 'other polyunsaturated fatty acids and vitamin D' (OR = 0.48, 95% CI: 0.31-0.74) were inversely related to esophageal cancer. No significant association was observed for the other patterns. **CONCLUSION:** Our findings suggest that a diet rich in foods from animal origin and poor in foods containing vitamins and fiber increase esophageal cancer risk.